

One reason for interest in the question of whether life after death is possible is the thought that, if there is no life after death, then death would be a terrible thing.

But there is an ancient tradition which says that this is a mistake: that death, even if there is no life after death, is nothing to be feared. (Note that we should distinguish the fear of death from the fear of dying — no one disputes that dying painfully can be a bad thing.)



Lucretius, a Roman philosopher who lived in the first century B.C., was part of this tradition. In his poem *De Rerum Natura* (*On the Nature of Things*), he gave two short and intriguing arguments against the idea that death is at all a bad thing.

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I fear death?

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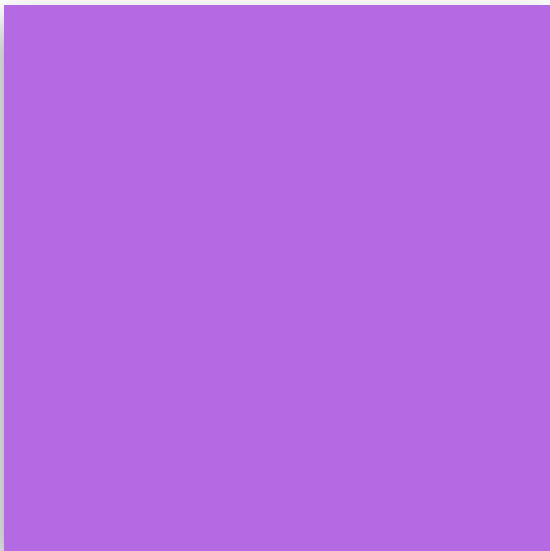
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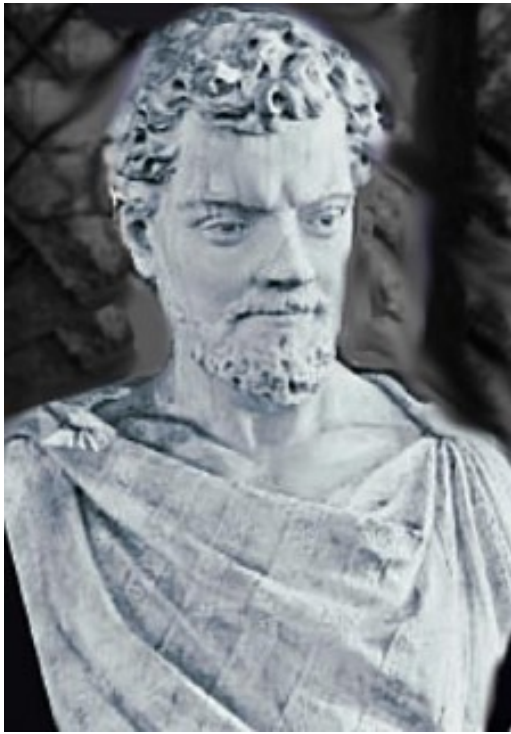
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